seen growth across all segments and price points, with travel becoming a key part of every household's budget plan.

The coming decade is particularly exciting due to the growing interest of Indian travellers in exploring the vast expanses of our own country. Nurturing this momentum will be critical. Further, catching the eye of the discerning, high-spending international tourist with a rooted presence in key source markets is essential for our future growth. But many of India's premier destinations are grappling with the challenges of overtourism. Integrating the concept of carrying capacity into our strategic planning is essential for a sustainable and prosperous future for the industry.

THE GIANT STEPS

- Develop 200 model destinations with improved connectivity and experiences
- Enhance infrastructure through better roads, trains and air connectivity
- Implement sustainable tourism practices to address overtourism
- Foster public–private collaboration for aligned promotion and policies

Infrastructure boost: Time and convenience of travel and choices of accommodation, activities and experiences at the destinations determine the propensity to travel. We can draw inspiration from the success stories across India, where direct flights, new train routes and destination-level rejuvenation have made travel and tourism more accessible. The government's focus on building roads, developing fast train services like Vande Bharat and expanding air connectivity with schemes like UDAN has already begun to reduce travel times, making intra-India travel more appealing.

While the popular destinations are now facing capacity strains, it is important for us to develop at least 200 model destinations on a war footing. Again, it is important to facilitate last-mile connectivity, ensure the availability of quality and standard accommodation, and build activities, exploration opportunities and experiences to hold the tourists for 2-3 days. This will not only unlock the cultural tapestry of our nation but also invigorate local economies and support sustainable tourism. Popular hotspots suffering from overtourism will also get an opportunity to recover, which is vital for long-term sustainability.

Homestays have also become an integral part of the tourism landscape, catering to the evolving preferences of travellers. The burgeoning homestay industry offers travellers the ethos of 'Atithi Devo Bhava' while showcasing the most beautiful interior parts of the country. The Indian government has recognised the potential of homestays in promoting tourism and supporting local communities. However, we need more uniform and conducive policies tailored to enable the homestay ecosystem to flourish.

Public-private synergy: Globally, tourism is hugely private, driven with government support and nimble policies. In India's federal structure, while the Union ministry of tourism provides the overarching structure, states have their own policies to drive tourism at the ground level. It is crucial for the public and private sectors to collaborate and align on what to promote and how to promote it. To facilitate ease of doing business and incentivise private equity, there needs to be a greater focus on creating uniform frameworks.

Striving for sustainability: Travel offers numerous benefits, but leaves behind one major negative: a carbon footprint. We cannot become a successful tourism destination until we, as travellers, adapt and learn to travel responsibly. Sustainable travel isn't a special kind of travel; it's an attitude. By remembering that the places we visit are someone's home and adjusting our practices to sustain these destinations for future travellers, we can help preserve our crumbling tourist spots for future generations. It is important that all tourism stakeholders must actively embrace and promote sustainability.

For instance, under the aegis of MakeMyTrip Foundation, our social development arm, we have been working towards building resilience in high tourist influx destinations. This includes implementing effective waste management solutions and promoting community-based tourism models. Furthermore, we have been working on environmental conservation with our afforestation initiatives, having planted and supported over 1.7 million saplings. By incorporating these practices, we aim to ensure that tourism remains a force for good, benefitting local communities and preserving the natural beauty of our destinations for future generations.

As we chart this path towards making India the next global tourism powerhouse, let's celebrate our heritage, harness our strengths and work together to create a future where India stands tall as a beacon of world-class tourism. Nature has bestowed us with an unparalleled bounty, and the onus is on us to ensure that we can sustainably leverage it to the fullest. If we get it all correct, I will not be surprised to see India among the most travelled countries worldwide in the next two decades. ■

The author is Founder & Chairman, MakeMyTrip